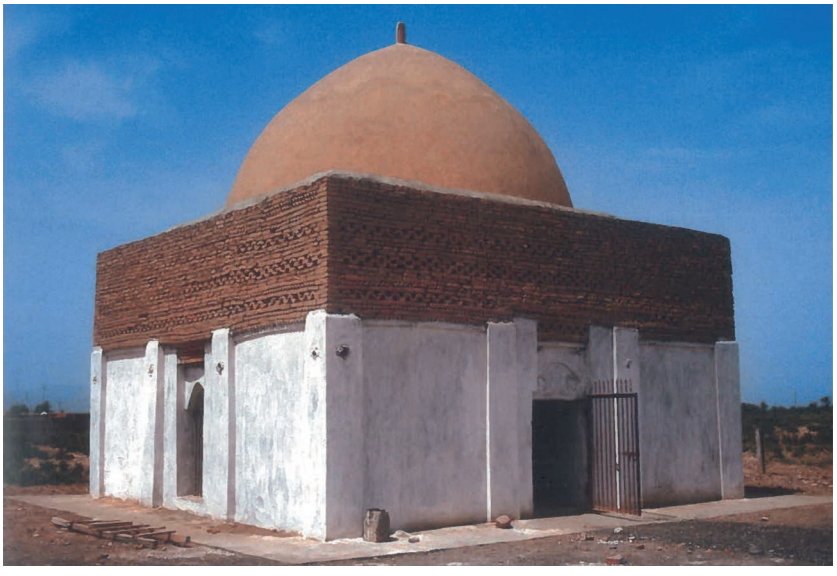


Figure 6.10 *Tomb attributed to Muhammad ibn Harun, Lasbela, Baluchistan, Pakistan. From Edwards 2006, fig. 3.*

and predominant among the various Baluch and other groups and confederacies settled or transhumant in the region, supporting the attribution of these mortuary structures to them. Indeed, the selective adaptations and reinterpretations of Islamic orthodoxy among nomadic pastoralists and other transhumant groups permitted the continuation of non-Islamic customs, which could be the basis for figuration on these nominally "Islamic" structures.[37]

Notably, the lavish decoration of the above-described commemorations was reduced to a series of "textile-like band[s] of carved brickwork" on the tomb of Muhammad ibn Harun – predictably without figuration – and relegated to the upper parts of its elevation. The tomb's interior was also plain except for a pointed-arch *mihrab* within a rectangular frame of zigzag bricks.[38] Taken altogether, it appears that the practice of cladding built surfaces with decorated terracotta plaques was a wide-ranging indigenous practice throughout Makran–Baluchistan and Sindh, documentable at least since the mid-first millennium CE on pre-Islamic remains,[39] and adapted to the architectural needs – quite possibly of a funerary nature – of settling or transitory populations such as the Baluch nomadic pastoralists and others. Ultimately, terracotta cladding was also integrated into the Islamic tombs of the region, but without the "non-Islamic" iconographies. Indeed, it is difficult to sustain a strict division between figural/pre- or non-Islamic, and non-figural/Islamic decoration, so that figural and non-figural plaques may have been made concurrently for different patrons.